

Essentials of Moral Realism

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ESSENTIALS OF MORAL REALISM

This is a very short book on morality, what it is and what it means to us. Thought I hope to clarify a few things.

First, there are my friends who don't recognize a lawgiver for the universe, and therefor jump to the idea that morals are subjective. Real morals truths exist without the need for a lawgiver.

Second, there are my friends who claim that morality can only come from an external lawgiver, and I hope to show that to be a hasty conclusion. There are in fact mechanisms in the world that underly our moral behavior that have nothing to do with a lawgiver.

I have kept this as short and to the point as I can, but I give references to places where you can explore more on the topics.

Please enjoy.

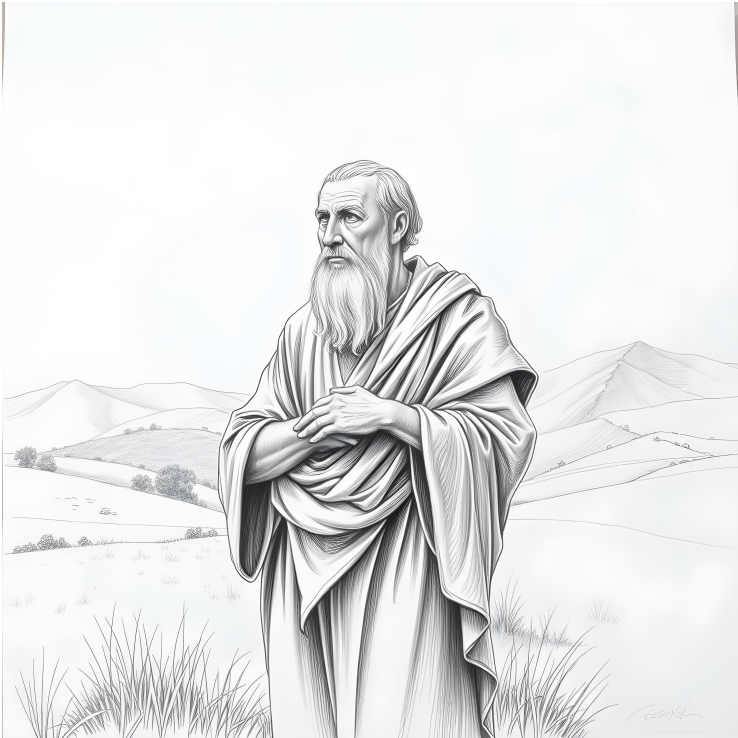


Figure 1.: Philosopher

INTRODUCTION

This book is for everyone who has lived, and wondered what was the right way to live. It may be easy to know what you want to do at the moment, but how should I live my life the right way that will preserve what I have short term gain, only to find that I have squandered more in the long term as a consequence.

Ancient philosophers debated ethics and morality, which is the topic of how to live the *right life* (also called the *good life* or *eudaimonia*). It is a question that was probably first asked at the time mankind first began to talk.

Many of my non-religious friends struggle to understand what should be considered the source of morality. These are fine upstanding moral people. They understand what it means to be fair, good, and kind. They would not live their lives any other way. But they are not really sure where morals come from.

So much written about morality comes from a religious point of view. The Christians and the Muslims each arrogantly claim to have an exclusive access to morality, and readily spew invectives calling everyone else is baseless immoral heathens, especially atheists. History is replete with examples of religious wars, religious persecution, burning atheists at stakes for not believing the right things, and so many examples of religions not living up to the claim of being moral.

Most non-religious friends live as moral a life as any churchgoer. Like most people, they have a sense of right and wrong. But the question remains: where does that sense of right and wrong come from? Is it, as the Christians insist, the result of a God commanding us to behave a certain way? If not God, then how do we explain that there are right and wrong ways to do

things? Did they occur randomly? Many atheists turn to the idea that morality is subjective, that the best way to live is whatever you decide it to be, I will show that to be a mistaken concept as well.

What I aim to do here is to blaze a middle path along the golden mean which postulates that a pattern of right behavior does exist, and they come neither from God, nor are they random. Moral behavior is as it is because of the form of human interaction with each other and with the world. Humans have learned how to behave morally through a self-reinforcing natural process that can be readily seen in the world once we know how to look for it. Moral guidelines are not an accident, nor are they commandments from the supernatural. Instead we can say succinctly: **we discovered the best way to live because it is the best way to live.**

That may sound confusing at first, so We will proceed cautiously:

1. The first chapter will start with some definitions so that we have a foundation to discuss morality with confidence. So much has been written that most words are used in many ways, so we will set out with some care what we mean here.
2. Goodness is not an arbitrary preference. There is a fact to the matter, that good actions are meaningfully good in that they consist of behavior that helps the tribe to survive. A tribe that adopts bad morals would not survive. The connection between survival and the goodness of actions has been largely overlooked, and that connection makes morality real.
3. Subjective morality is the first trap and the place where many non-religious people tread feeling that there is no other choice between that and religious morality. This is a mistake, and we will explore the various ways that subjective morality does not fill the need.
4. Moral Relativism is the second trap we will explore is which is professed by few however it is important to

- clearly distinguish what this is and why it is not reasonable.
5. There is no magic in the formation of objective truths. I will cover a couple of analogous situations in which objective truths emerge from the physicality of the universe. This will support the idea that objective moral truths emerge from human behavior in an evolutionary fashion.
 6. We then glance quickly at religious/biblical morality as a form of objective morality but it has traps of its own.
 7. Moral Objectivism is then presented in a way contrasted with the other approaches.
 8. Love is the concluding topic of the book.
 9. Call to Action, how to use this in your daily life. How to talk clearly about moral foundations with others.
 10. References and Resources

I hope you will join me though the complete journey.

CHAPTER 1

TERMS OF DISCUSSION

We start with some definitions of terms, none of which are intended to be controversial. In this work I will use these terms in these ways.

good/right — Good has many meanings, but we will stick to the meaning of morally good. Actions, qualities, or principles are morally good when they are considered right, virtuous, benevolent, and beneficial. Doing the right thing, is to act morally good. Such as being kind to people is morally good. Instead of saying something is physically good for you, we can use the term beneficial. So that there is no confusion, if something feels good, we will call it pleasurable. If something tastes good, we will call it delectable. Instead of saying that the student picked the right answer, we will use the term correct answer.

bad/evil/wrong — We will use these words interchangeably to mean simply morally bad, the opposite of morally good. The word 'evil' will not necessarily be used to mean profoundly bad, but just the action is not morally good. Instead of saying that the student picked the wrong answer, we will use the term incorrect answer. If I use the term 'sin' it will mean the same as a bad or evil action.

good life/eudaimonia — means a morally good life, a life where the actions you make are morally good, but at the same time quite possibly be beneficial for you and your tribe. The

good life is a life where you make all the best decisions along the way so that you always maintain what Aristotle calls the golden mean where you neither sacrifice too much, nor do you squander too much. It is a life with neither excess nor deficiency.

Morality vs. Ethics

Morality and ethics are guidelines for finding the good life. I won't be giving you any specific guidelines, but instead discussing how these guidelines have come about and the reason why we should be able to trust them. There is a subtle difference between these terms:

Morals — Refers to personal beliefs about right and wrong, often shaped by cultural, religious, or personal values. They are more subjective and can vary greatly between individuals and societies.

Ethics — Refers to systematic rules or principles governing conduct, often established by professional organizations, institutions, or societies. Ethics are more objective and provide a framework for making decisions in various contexts.

Morality - Refers to the idea that specific actions can be identified as either leading toward or away from the good life. We attempt to identify whether an action is good or bad through the use of moral rules (which are simplistic approximations) or moral guidelines (which more complete yet often intractable).

Moral Optimum — Refers to the idea that there could be a moral guideline that describes the best way to behave across any given context. Simply put: for any given situation, from the set of all possible actions, there is a best action to choose. Nobody knows the moral optimum for sure, but we strive to approximate this optimum as best we can.

Morals in Action

Morality is concerned with distinguishing what is right from what is wrong; good actions from evil actions; sin from virtue.

In all cases we are talking about *conduct* which is a set of actions that an agent does. Here are some definitions of morality from dictionaries:

- a doctrine or system of moral conduct
- conformity to ideals of right human conduct
- The quality of being in accord with standards of right or good conduct
- A system or collection of ideas of right and wrong conduct

Acts/Actions — are things a person might decide to perform. Everything that we actually do is composed of actions. Morality, simply put, is a way to distinguish good actions (those which you should do) from bad actions (those which you should not do). Note that the term *should* is used simply to connote that an action is good. The morality of an action is only important if someone can decide whether to do it or not.

Context — The morality of an action depends not only on the act itself, but also the context which is the situation around the action and everyone who was involved. Starting a fire in a campsite fireplace is probably a good action, starting a fire in a crowded airplane definitely a bad action. The entire situation must be considered when assessing the morality of an action.

Agent - is the person deciding to do the action. I will use this interchangeably with person, but they are not always equivalent.

Tribe - I will use this term for any group of individuals trying to work together. Today tribe can mean many things: your community, your city, your school, your family, your nation, etc. To keep from having to spell these different grouping in every occasion, tribe will be used to mean a collection of people working together at any scale.

Subjective — is about things defined within the mind in relation to perceptions which might be unique to each individual subject:

- characteristic of or belonging to reality as perceived rather than as independent of mind

- relating to or being experience or knowledge as conditioned by personal mental characteristics or states
- peculiar to a particular individual
- arising out of or identified by means of one's perception of one's own states and processes
- Not caused by external stimuli.
- Dependent on or taking place in a person's mind rather than the external world.

We will spend a lot of time exploring what it means for morals to be subjective but it is clear that anything that is subjective is something that is unique to that person and possibly only knowable by that person. Your feelings are subjective because nobody else can feel them.

Objective — is about things that are outside of an individual mind, and can be observed by any number of people the same way:

- expressing or dealing with facts or conditions as perceived without distortion by personal feelings, prejudices, or interpretations
- having reality independent of the mind
- involving or deriving from sense perception or experience with actual objects, conditions, or phenomena
- not influenced by personal feelings, interpretations, or prejudice; based on facts; unbiased
- intent upon or dealing with things external to the mind rather than with thoughts or feelings

Layers and Scope

To be able to talk about morals clearly, we need to distinguish between the multiple layers and scope of morals. Much of the confusion in discussions of morality often have to do with

Moral Optimum — This is the ultimate valuation of whether a specific action was actually good or bad. These are objective, however people might disagree on what is and is not the

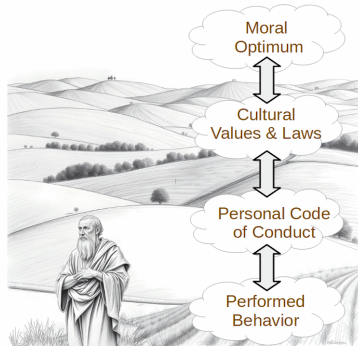


Figure 1.1.: image showing four layers of morality

optimum action because of differing understanding. These apply universally across space and time however different actions might be optimum at different places and times. A moral guideline that approaches the moral optimum will be extremely complex in order to account for all the possible extenuating circumstances.

Cultural Values & Laws — Cultures will embody statements about what is and is not good, usually expressed as a rule to follow. Some of these are formally written and adopted as laws. Moral rules and laws are different degrees of the same thing: they both encourage (or enforce) behavior which is considered to be good. Some cultural values are less explicit, and appear only as guidelines or simply a shared idea among the participants of the culture. Laws exist from local, to community, to city, to state, to country, and sometimes the whole world. Laws will occasionally conflict with each other. Because these are rules, they only approximate the real moral valence. The term **ethics** generally plays at this level.

Personal Code of Conduct — A set of rules that an individual claims or aspires to live by. These are largely adopted from the culture, but an individual does not always agree with their culture, especially when they find themselves in a multi-cultural situation where the individual might have to choose between two conflicting rules. These must be expressed as rules. It would be

the set of rules that an individual would claim to follow if they could. That set is limited to what a person can remember and internalize. The term **morals** generally plays at this level, when we talk about an individual having good morals or bad morals. Notice that comparing morals at this level implies some higher level morality to compare various morals.

Performed Actions — What an individual actually does. People follow their own rules most of the time, but sometimes it is too much trouble and shortcuts are taken. The actions are the true measure of what an individuals thinks is good or bad, and they are somewhat more pragmatic than the explicitly stated rules.

There is a tension between the bottom two as people try to put their own morals into action. Most people have an internalized code of conduct. They may have an intuitive understanding of right and wrong that transcends the rules they claim to follow. That is, there might be an explicit rule to turn someone in for a crime, however one might allow someone to get away because for some reason they did not deserve it. There may not be an explicit rule to cover the situation, however rules conflict in their detail, and one must use judgement in selecting which rules apply to which situation.

There is a tension between the personal code of conduct and the cultural values and laws. Most laws represent the morals of a culture in a written form. But in the case of an unjust law, it can be moral to show civil disobedience when the law can be shown to contradict other recognized moral rules. Your personal code of conduct may override the laws or cultural norms.

Sometimes a minority group embedded in a larger culture may be faced with conflicting rules they need to choose between. In this case the individual has to choose which cultural rules to follow, and which rules to breach. Again, the personal morals must guide that decision.

Finally it is also possible there is a tension between the top two. A culture may adopt practices it views as moral but in fact turn out to be immoral. Two examples: bloodletting and slavery.

CHAPTER 2

WHAT IS A GOOD ACTION?

What does it mean to say that an action is morally good? What makes a particular action morally bad? Where does “moral valence” (the measure of how good/bad an action is) come from?

Only Actions Matter

An act (or action) is a movement that affects the world that some agent decided to do. Thinking is not an action. Imagining is not an action. Movement that occurs without an agent deciding to do it, such as a snowstorm or a flower blooming, is not an action either. Normally all the non-action things that occur after an action, and yet correlated with it, are considered part of that action. For example an arsonist decides to light a house on fire, and the subsequent burning down of the house would be considered all part of the same action.

The moral value of that act is strictly about the consequence of that act. If the result of the action bring about an overall benefit to the world, then it is a good action. If the result causes harm in the world, then it is a bad, or evil, action. This is known as *Consequentialism*.

Wait, that is too easy. What if you don't want to do the morally good action? I am not saying that a moral action is an action that the

agent likes. A heroine addict probably likes the hit of the drug, but liking it certainly has no bearing on whether the act is good or not. Liking an action, and disliking an action, is completely different from whether the action is beneficial or not.

The right thing to do is not always beneficial to us. Morality is about the success of the tribe, not necessarily the individual. Moral guidelines help us to live together successfully, and by that means helping to assure the survival of all, but not always everyone. A soldier going off to war is doing the right moral thing for his country and his community, but they are also taking a big risk personally. Still, most soldiers do come home and the net benefit to their family and community is substantial.

What about two people who do the exact same thing? For example "lighting a fire." One person does it in a fireplace to heat the room full of freezing people. The other person does it on a crowded airplane while it is flying. Those are different acts, because they occur in different contexts. The next section is about how the result of an act depends on the context, and the same physical movement might have completely different outcomes.

Actions in Context

The action is not simply a movement of an agent, but it is that movement in the context of where they are, and all other people involved. The exact same movement might have completely different results. Breaking glass is normally a bad thing to do, but if there is a fire then breaking the glass to get to a fire alarm is considered a good thing.

For example, yelling "Fire" in a crowded theater when there is no fire is a well known bad thing to do, because people are likely to get hurt in the rush to get outside. But obviously if not in a theater, and if there is a fire, then it would probably be a good thing letting others know about the danger. We need to consider the specifics around a particular act, and the context it was performed in, and then consider the specific outcome, to decide if the act was good or bad.

Consider the act of “slicing meat”. Is that good or bad? It depends.

- If done by a cook, preparing a meal, it is probably a good thing.
- If done by a thug slicing an innocent bystander, it is probably a bad thing.
- If done by a surgeon slicing into a person to remove a ruptured appendix, it is probably a good thing.

The motion of “slicing meat” is the same at some level, but without knowing the context and the entire situation around it, we can never say whether that particular motion is good or bad. The motion, the context, and all the related situation must be considered together, and it is that entire combination that we will refer to as an “act” or “action” for the rest of this writing.

Action Scope and Duration

An act may be long or short in duration, and in the performing of one act, you might also at the same time be performing dozens of other actions. For example, the act of “going to college” can take four or more years. The act of entertaining someone might involve the action of cooking dinner, which in turn involves the act of cutting meat.

There is no definite boundary on any action. An action must be something that an agent can decide to do, or to not do. It is that decision that forms the need to know whether the act is moral or not.

In considering any situation, we must determine the actions that are available to us. As such, many actions are culturally defined. Different cultures, different regions, different groups, might break out what constitutes an “act” differently, and in some cases the judgement is built into the description. Did someone lie, or did they just say something too loosely? Or did they blaspheme? Or did they perjure themselves? Different cultures, or even sometimes simply people with different points of view,

will describe the same thing differently. When comparing different moral systems, one has to be careful to isolate the action to purely what was done, and not a description that selects according to a judgement.

Why Is Survival Good?

For a moment, let's consider a slightly different question: why does sugar taste good? Why does ice cream taste good? Ice cream is very rich in energy: sugar and fat are almost pure energy. Imagine a couple starving cave men happening upon an ice cream store. In cave man times life was rough and people lived on the edge of starvation, and a bad winter was life threatening due simply to not enough food, not enough energy, to live. Our two cave men have a difference: one absolutely loves the taste of fat and sugar, and the other hates it. The one who loves the taste will obviously fill up on the energy rich ice cream because you never quite know if you will encounter that again, while the other, the one who hates the taste of fat and sugar avoids eating the energy rich food. Which one is going to live longer?

Clearly sensing energy rich foods is a very important trait for survival. But we ask the question again: why does sugar taste sweet? Why is a sweet taste pleasurable? Is a sweet taste pleasurable *because* it has energy? Or, is it pleasurable simply because those that found it pleasurable tended to survive? A creationist might say: *God made sugar taste good so that we can find those high energy food sources*, but that gets it exactly backward. Those people who found sugar distasteful died out long ago. When the game is survival, those that associate pleasure with high energy food will win more often. We are the progeny of the winners.

The exact same thing happens with good behaviors. Do we recognize behaviors as being *good* because they help us get along? Exactly the other way around: those people who felt they should do something that helps the group survive, are the ones that survived. Those people who had a tendency to do

things you shouldn't do, died out long ago.

We have a sense about what is *good* and *evil*. It is not always right, but often it is. That sense had been learned over time. Early on, it might have been random: half did one thing, and the other half did the opposite. But over time, the bad ideas get weeded out.

Oriented to Collective Good

Good for whom? An action that is good only for the agent is considered selfish, and not really good in a moral sense. A right action needs to be good for more than the individual making the choice.

Good for what group? Humans naturally live in groups. A good action should be good for at least the immediate family or tribe, but even that really is not enough. While a particular tribe might find it convenient to throw their waste on another tribe's land, it would not be considered a moral act. There is a sense that a good action should be on the balance good for all of humanity.

Even humanity is not quite inclusive enough. We talk about animals rights along with the morality of cruelty to animals. So what is the scope? There is a feeling that the action has to be right from some kind of universal perspective. That is, a good action is fundamentally good in itself.

Is Good Really Good

This might be something that is shown to be good for you, and good for your tribe, but is it really *good* in the moral sense? *What if you or your tribe are actually bad and it would be a good thing to wipe you out.*

This argument is appealing to the mystery of morality, the idea that an action can only be moral if the action was commanded by a superior being. It is also a dismissal of the idea that an action can actually be moral in itself and because of its

consequences. This debate was argued by Socrates in Euthyphro which presents a dilemma: either there are moral truths that transcend even God, or else moral values are arbitrary and simply picked by God. You can't have it both ways.

To think that moral value of something is arbitrary and simply picked by omniscient god means that moral values are not real, but only arbitrary. Some believers might decide that is more comfortable to them, but we need not believe in the arbitrary moral maker. There are good ways that the actions produce good results as a consequence — on average across many people and in the appropriate situations. The moral value of such actions are not arbitrary. There exist moral truths, and the next chapter goes into detail on how these exist and how they come about.

Moral Propositions don't Matter

Some people like to frame the moral debate in terms of propositions (statements that something is good or not) and whether those statements are true or false.

This is a dead end, because a proposition can be never be complete. You can saying "lying is bad" but that can never be completely true or completely false because it does not include the context, nor does the work "lying" clearly define a specific set of actions. Until you actually lie, in a specific context, and in whatever way you do it, you can never be certain it will be good or bad.

Avoiding stating the meta-ethics in this way avoids a lot of problems. For example the moral nihilists (a.k.a. error theorists) claim that no moral statement can ever be made, because those statements are actually about imperative commands, wishes, or desires, and not about the morality of the situation.

A phrase of any sort will never be a complete description of any situation, and thus we can't just the description, we can only judge an actual act in a particular context. The moral rules are approximations which are simplifications that are useful, but

they are not themselves actually correct about right and wrong.

CHAPTER 3

MORAL RULES ARE INADEQUATE

We often discuss morality in terms of “rules to live by.”. In this chapter I want to make a distinction between the logic that guides moral behavior, and the rules that we use when discussing what should and should not be done.

Rules are Simple

Rules are short simple statements to guide behavior. Some example rules are:

- Don't lie
- Don't steal
- Don't break windows or otherwise damage someone else's property
- Do help feed orphans

Those rules are stated in imperative form, but we can also state them in evaluative form which is useful for assessing the morality of behaviors:

- lying is bad
- stealing is bad
- breaking windows and damaging other's property is bad

- helping to feed orphans is good

The thing to note about rules is that they are short and simple. Their brevity makes them useful. Rules can be said quickly, and they communicate a great deal of value in guiding behavior. They can be used as a rough guide for behavior for a large variety of situations. For example: don't enter that room. Or, don't touch the wires. Always close the door behind you. There could be many good reasons to avoid or promote these behaviors, but listing out all those reasons is tedious and time consuming. Giving a short rule might be all you need to know to act morally most of the time.

Slicing Actions Apart

The swirl of motion in the universe needs to be broken into separate identifiable repeatable patterns which we name in order to talk about them. The way to divide motion into patterns is somewhat arbitrary. The way you divide motions into recognized behaviors can depend on the cultural setting, which both affects and is affected by the customs of that culture. Yet the common human condition across the world leads similar definitions for all the most common behaviors.

The descriptions of behavior classify the action so that we can then talk about whether it should or should not be done. Talking is just saying something, but lying is the special case of purposefully saying a falsehood. Perjury is the special case of lying when you are specifically compelled by law to tell the truth.

The way we define behaviors is often directly tied to moral reasoning about those behaviors. Cheating, for instance, describes any behavior at all that is contrary to the rules in force at the moment. Transferring of money can be a perfectly good thing to do, but we call it "embezzling" when this transfer is done in a context where you should not transfer that money. Jaywalking is the act of crossing a street in a place where you should not cross the street, and in some parts of the world jaywalking simply does not exist.

To recognize an action, we need to “slice it out” of reality: that is we select a set of facts that we believe relevant to the situation, and then we classify according to those facts. From whatever is happening, we need to classify the action into some identified form which can then be subject to rules. The classification of actions is culture dependent. The same actual occurrence might be classified several different ways, by different people, using differing levels of detail.

Rules can be short because they leverage well-known defined behaviors, and some behaviors are defined purely to be used in rules about whether you should or should not do them.

Rules are Approximate

Because of their brevity, rules can't be fully accurate across the broad variety of real situations.

We know that lying is bad, but we also know that a “white lie” is OK. Honesty is generally good, but there are cases where brutal honesty can be quite bad. Tactfulness is the art of knowing when to tell the truth, and when to tell a white lie. The subtle detail about exactly how honest to be can not be summed up in any short or useful form.

Some rules apply 99% of the time, and some are closer to 60% of the time, but it is understood that for all rules, there will be exceptions. In most cases, the validity of the exception will depend upon specifics of the situation which we call the context.

Context

Rules apply differently in different contexts. A good rule applies in all the most normally encountered situations, but there will always be unusual situations, known as exceptional situations, where the rule should not be followed. We rely on some measure of common knowledge to distinguish exceptional situations where the rule should be ignored.

Chapter 3. Moral Rules are Inadequate

For example, generally breaking a window is bad, because it is costly to replace. But if there is a fire, you are often expected to break the glass to get to and activate the fire alarm. Breaking a window is normally bad, but perfectly acceptable if done to help rescue a person trapped in a burning house or car.

For example, throwing someone out of the house in the middle of the night might be perfectly acceptable act in the tropics where the night is mild. But throwing someone out of the house in the middle of the night in antarctica might carry a risk of death, and would be a very bad thing to do. The difference is context, not subjectivity. No matter who you are, and what your subjective opinions, the act of throwing someone out in an arctic night is a completely different thing than throwing them out in the tropics.



We all know that context makes a difference. For example killing a person is generally a bad thing to do. But killing a sniper in a tower who is shooting innocent people below might make the world safe for others. We know that it is justified to shoot someone in self defense if you believe your life is in danger.

We know that lying is a bad behavior, but in the classic example when the Nazis show up asking about Jews hiding there, one would be perfectly morally justified in lying. Context matters.

This does not mean that the person answering the door of Anne Frank has different morals than us. It means instead that the morality of lying depends on whether the a life depends on whether we lie or not. The rule about lying is not simply “don’t ever lie” but instead something like “don’t lie unless there is a

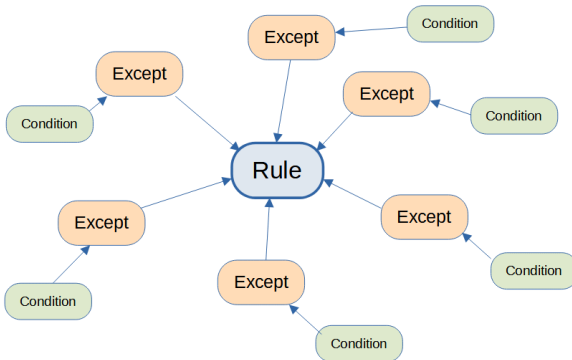
good reason to lie then it is OK.”

Moral Guidelines Are Not So Simple

We are limited beings, and as such we would like simple rules to live by. Rules like “do X” and “don’t do Y” would be great because they are easy to remember and to tell each other.

Unfortunately reality is never simple. It is complex. Everyone is interacting with everyone all the time in different contexts. The real rules for behavior come with lots of assumed exceptions and special cases which are not stated in the rule.

The purposeful crashing of UA flight 93 in a field in Pennsylvania on 9/11 was a good thing given that otherwise the plane would have been used to cause thousands more deaths. It would be impossible to include this as an explicit exception to the rule: “Don’t ever purposefully crash airplanes except if some terrorists have taken over the plane and hope to use it to cause even more death.” There could be thousands of such exceptions — even exceptions we can’t dream of today.



Simple rules can't express the whole story

When we see that morality appears to be different in different cultures, we need to consider the context that the culture lives in. Morality for an Inuit may be different than morality for a Tahitian but what is different is the simplistic guideline that we use in place of the real, complex moral equation. The differences between cultures can be explained by a single complex rule that applies differently to different environment.

Or one of them might be simply wrong. But in any case we will see that morals can not be different for different people just because they wish them to be.

Moral Rules are Inadequate in Four Ways

Brevity: a rule can be stated in a brief sentence: “don’t break windows”. For most windows you encounter — probably more than 99.99% of them — if you follow this rule you will be safe. But occasionally there are situations that are exceptions. If there is a fire, and someone is trapped inside, it is OK to break the window to save them. We put glass in front of fire alarms for the same reason: if there really is a fire then breaking the window is preferable to letting the fire burn down the house.

Classification: Rules talk about a set of actions which are categorized in a certain way. For example:

- Using a knife to slice meat for a meal
- Using a knife to slice a person on the street
- Using a knife to slice a person to remove a ruptured appendix

The first is a good action normally part of preparing food. The second adds context to describe an attack which is bad. The third adds more context to refine the situation into surgery which might be life saving and good.

Scope: It is generally the case that the action can be defined by the immediate surroundings at the time, but in some cases situ-

ations quite far away or removed in time might have relevance. An act that is permissible in private, might be illegal in public. An act performed in one city or state might be legal while the same act in a different state is illegal. It is possible that an occurrence on the other side of the world has bearing. Considering the entire state of the entire universe is not possible nor reasonable, so some judgement needs to be used to assure that enough scope is included to decide the morality of an action.

Exceptions: To keep the rules brief, there is an understanding that for every rule there are a number of exceptions which counteract the regular rule. In an emergency, a lot of things become permissible, but then what exactly is an emergency? What are all the exceptional situations for breaking a window? In a perfect moral system it might be that every rule would be complete and would stand alone and unambiguous, but those rules would be incredibly detailed, impossible to learn, impossible to recite, and not usable on a daily basis.

In The End

The conclusion is that when we talk about morals, we need to express them in terms of rules or laws which are by their very nature approximate, and can not possibly describe accurately what is and is not moral. They work more like 99% of the time, with the remaining 1% unspecified.

CHAPTER 4

SUBJECTIVE MORALITY

Subjective Morality, also known as Moral Subjectivism, is the *Philosophical belief that moral truths are not universal or absolute, but are instead dependent upon the attitudes, feelings, opinions, or conventions of individuals or groups.*

Subjective does not necessarily mean related to feeling; it simply means that it varies from person to person (*subiectum* is Latin for the agent in a sentence or situation).

To say that a morality is subjective is to say that what is *good* varies from person to person. *Good* is by this reasoning nothing more than the opinion of an individual or a tribe. This elevates a preference to be the very definition of what is absolutely good, at the same time eliminating the possibility that a preference might be wrong.

Tip

Bob feeds the orphans. We (the observers) can say that this is a good act if we feel that helping vulnerable children is a good thing to do and makes us feel good. Sam does not feed the orphans. We can say that Sam's action is bad, because it feels bad to leave children vulnerable to starvation.

Meaning Of Subjective

The best example of a subjective claim is that of your favorite flavor of ice cream. When faced with choosing a flavor, however you pick that is based on your own memory of experiences in the past, and your own estimation of what you would like to experience today. If you decide that “Cherry Garcia” is your favorite flavor, then that is what your favorite flavor is.

Nobody can say you are wrong. I can not say that your favorite is not that, or that in fact your favorite flavor is “Dutch Chocolate”. I can suggest arguments that it should not be such, but I can not truthfully say that you are *wrong* about your favorite. I have no access to your memories or your desires. A subjective claim is true if you say it is true, and nobody can argue otherwise.

If a moral claim was subjective, then whatever you claim would by definition be true. If you claim that drinking alcohol is actually a good moral behavior, then nobody can ever say you are wrong. Alcohol drinking would be *good* (for you) because you say it is good.

Actions Have Objective Consequences

An individual can not simply decide what is *good* and *bad* based on their personal preferences, because actions have consequences which affect the world. The result of the action is not just a preference.

You can pass a law requiring a behavior, but you can’t simply decide that the law is *good*. For example: if you made a law that every person has to chop off their right hand. You can pass that law, but the law is inherently *bad* because the entire society will be harmed and will do worse when nobody has two hands, more people will die, more people will starve, more people will suffer. These make the law bad no matter what you decide.

400 years ago the practice of bloodletting was considered a right and moral action. The theory was that too much blood was

the cause of some illness. A majority of doctors agreed that letting out the excess blood was the right thing to do. Bloodletting was *good* and in fact it would have been immoral to prevent a doctor from performing bloodletting in those situations. Later we learned that actually the problem is not that there is too much blood, and in fact removal of blood would actually weaken the sick person. It was the discovery of the adverse consequence of bloodletting that we were able to determine that bloodletting itself is immoral. Even though people mistakenly thought it was moral, no amount of thinking it was moral can actually make it moral.

An action that causes harm is bad, even if you subjectively think it is good.

The Claim And The Reality

Much of the source of disagreement comes from the semantics of the word morality. In the first chapter on definition, I point out four concepts of morality. There is a layer (3) where people claim what they believe to be moral, and then there is a different layer (1) for what is actually universally moral.

Some culture may decide that capital punishment is a good and moral thing and to make a law instituting the practice. Still, we can discuss whether the law is actually moral or not, and this discussion implies and depends upon there being some kind of higher moral ground upon which to base the comparison.

When someone says that morality is subjective they simply do not believe that there is any higher objective basis upon which to compare actions. Whatever you believe to be moral actually is moral.

For example, I believe it is moral to eat ice cream on Sunday. That is just a claim that I make, but it might or might not actually be moral. I might be wrong. There might be some reason that eating ice cream on Sunday is bad for everyone, and decreases the survivability of the community. (I doubt it, but the point is that I can be wrong about this claim.)

Claiming that eating ice cream on Sunday is moral, does not make it moral. There exists a deeper objective moral assessment that can be used (if we know it) to state that my claim is right or wrong. That is what the universal morals do, and I will establish that there are reasons that opinions on morality can be shown to be objectively right or wrong.

What Is The Problem?

By arguing that morals are just subjective, we lose the higher moral ground from which to persuade the right action in situations. A subjective opinion where the statement of the opinion makes it so. You favorite ice cream is your favorite and nobody can say you are wrong. But your claim about morality can be right or wrong, and that is what tells us that morality is not subjective.

CHAPTER 5

MORAL RELATIVISM

Moral relativism takes one step further than moral subjectivism. Not only are there no moral truths, only moral opinions, but everyone's opinions are right for them.

Tip

Bob feeds the orphans. This is a good act because Bob simply feels that helping vulnerable children is a good thing to do and makes him feel good. Sam does not feed the orphans. This is a good act because Sam does not feel that his involvement is needed at this time.

Consequence of Subjective Morality

If you truly believe that morality is subjective, then you must accept the reality of moral relativism as well. If Bob says that bloodletting is a good moral action, then by subjective morality it is a good a moral action for him. If Sam says that bloodletting is not moral, then by subjective morality is it bad for him. Sam and Bob have conflicting opinions but the moral relativist says they are both correct.

You have to hold in your head that bloodletting is both good and bad. Each different person defines a different set of morals, and according to subjective morality, those are true morals for each of them at the same time. But how can bloodletting be both moral and immoral at the same time, for different people?

Moral relativist have to believe that the morality of Bob is independent of the morality of Sam. If you go to Bob's house, then bloodletting really is good for you. But at Sam's house it really is bad.

CHAPTER 6

OBJECTIVE TRUTHS

How can there be truths that come about in a natural way? Do they just randomly appear out of nothing?

These are the kind of questions that theists ask when they are convinced that God created moral truths, and they can't see how such truths could form naturally. In this chapter I hope to let you see that such truths are not surprising and would naturally fall out of any situation where such a difference would matter.

Boat Design Analogy

Is there an objective truth about the design of boats, and if so, who created those truths?

Consider the ancient coracle boat which is the simplest boat possible and it is a design that was created by humans 100,000 years ago. One can imagine ancient humans running a competition to see who, among a field of such boats, could get to the finish line the fastest.

As time went on, boat design advanced in many ways and with many materials. Each advance made a boat that was objectively better up to the fastest sailing boats that humans have ever made: the Americas Cup winners. Through trial and testing



of many different design options, boat makers found out what worked and what does not work as far as making a sailing boat go fast. The monohull gave way to the catamaran. Carbon fiber replaced wood. Tall sails were found more effective than wide sails. Etc.



Of course different designs will be optimal for different purposes. If you need to transport a large amount of oil from one continent to another, then a very different design will be optimal. The design is related to the purpose, but an optimal design can be said to exist for any purpose.

The point is that there are objective truths about boat design. Some design patterns are better than others. Who invented these truths?

Nobody invented the truths about good boat design. The par-

ticular optimal design for a sailing both simply comes from the properties of water, from the strength of gravity on earth, and on the details of the atmosphere and weather the boat needs to sail in. These truths about boat design exist without anyone creating them.

Dog Morality

Dogs have moral truths as well. There is a kind of dog morality that helps the pack function. Some of these are so obvious; for example a dog does not kill another dog in the pack, that is, murder is not allowed. Not all animals do this. Dogs have specific rules about eating. Dogs respect property rights; they don't steal things that other dogs own.



Dogs are social animals that need to cooperate to survive. They have to work together. That means there has to be rules about how they interact. These rules are either instinctual or taught from parent to pup. If they are taught, then how did this ability to teach and to learn moral rules develop?

The fact of the matter is that there is a moral truth about the optimum way for dogs to behave together. There are ways of acting that work for the betterment of the pack, and there are ways that harm the pack. Who invented those? Nobody/nothing invented them.

The optimal way for a dog to act for the betterment of the pack (and ultimately themselves) is a consequence of the form of the dog and the environment they live in. Approximations to the

optimal were found by trial and error. Dogs that behaved closer to the optimal, survived better. Those that behaved further from the optimal tended to die out. Thus the more optimal dogs survived, and that is why dogs behave as they do.

Human Morality Too

Objective truths in any category do not need to be created by anyone or any thing. They are simply a consequence of physicality. There is always a best way to do something.

Behaviors, like those of human societies, will tend to approach these optimums if the behavior matters for survival, and if the behavior can be transmitted from generation to generation. This is an evolutionary process.

Humans must work together to survive, and the better they work, the better they survive. The bad actions are lost when the actors die.

CHAPTER 7

BIBLICAL MORALITY

Theists in general agree that morals must be objective, and they see these morals coming from God.

Tip

Bob feeds the orphans. This is a good act because God commands us to take care of vulnerable children. Sam does not feed the orphans. This is bad for the same reason. If God had not commanded this, the act of feeding orphans would be neither good nor bad.

Moral Foundation Needed

Christians rightly argue that without objective morality, there can be no basis for talking about what one should and should not do. If my morals can be different from your morals, then anything I do is right, and anything you do is right as well.

If everybody can claim that sea level is defined by whatever level they are at, it becomes very difficult to talk about the altitude difference between two people: both are at sea level, even if one is thousands of feet higher.

Divine Command Theory

While theists may be right about the need and existence of universal moral truths, they make a simplistic assumption about the source: they say that God must have simply created them, along with everything else that God created in the world.



It has been that pattern in all primitive cultures that when those people can not imagine the source of something, when they can not understand how they form, they then simply conclude that something must have made it. Since the making of such things are inconceivably hard, they assume the maximally powerful being would be needed, and there is only one of those: God.

Knowability of God's Truths

The bible itself is inconsistent about moral advice.

- Slavery, now regarded as evil, was accepted by the writers of the bible as normal behavior
- Food illnesses caused various taboos that are no longer relevant since germ theory was discovered
- Practices around dealing with leprosy and other diseases were often harmful

- The old testament is filled with stories of holy genocide. The early tribes of Israel were in fact warring tribes, and the myths of a bible are clearly meant to motivate the population to do the will of the warlord. How can the destruction of the Amalekites possibly be considered moral?



Mature Christians don't claim that morality comes from the bible, but that God's morality was written on the hearts of men, atheist and theist alike. We know right from wrong, and you have a choice in following.

Righteous Arrogance

While it is good that Christians aspire to be moral, the insistence that they are the only possible moral actors in the world does a deep disservice to the hundreds of other traditions that are equally moral. And history has not shown Christians to be any more moral than any other major world culture.

Christians seem to be blind to the good actors that are around them, even going so far as to claim that non-Christians are simply accidentally acting on Christian sourced principles without knowing it.

Lawgiver is Unnecessary

Thinking that moral truths must be invented by a God is as silly as thinking that boat design truths must be invented by God. The fact is that these truths are true because they work, and not because of any divine manufacture.

This view on morality completely eliminates the Euthyphro Dilemma: Good actions are not good because God commands them, but instead they are good because they work to the success of the actors.

Questions

“Here’s a question for those who deny God: If you don’t believe in absolute truth, on what basis do you condemn bearing false witness? According to God’s standard, false witnesses are accountable and deserve justice (Deuteronomy 19:18–19). But in a worldview without God, where morality is subjective, isn’t lying just another choice? So, what’s your basis for condemning it—personal preference?”

Banning lies has a beneficial effect on the society that bans them. People in that society live longer, live better, and survive to produce more offspring.

A society that says it is OK to lie will die out. It is as simply as that: allowing lies is evil for this reason. Banning lies is good for this reason.

No god is needed. Morality is not subjective.

What Christians Say about Others

“In a world without God, there can be no objective right and wrong, only our culturally and personally relative, subjective judgments. This means that it is impossible to condemn war, oppression, or crime as

evil. Nor can one praise brotherhood, equality, and love as good. For in a universe without God, good and evil do not exist—there is only the bare valueless fact of existence, and there is no one to say you are right and I am wrong.” — William Lane Craig, ‘The Absurdity of Life without God’, TheHuffingtonPost.com, 18 Dec 2013

Even without God, we can appeal to something outside of our ‘culturally and personally relative, subjective judgments’.

“. . . this indignation is perfectly groundless if we ourselves regard morality as a subjective sentiment to be altered at will. Unless there is some objective standard of good, overarching Germans, Japanese, and ourselves alike whether any of us obey it or no, then of course the Germans are as competent to create their ideology as we are to create ours.” — C. S. Lewis, ‘The Poison of Subjectivism’, Christian Reflections

Moral objectivity requires forgetting nationality; thinking impartially. E.g.: Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR).

“A good atheist — that is, a consistent atheist — recognizes this dilemma. His only reasonable conclusion is to reject objective meaning and morality. Thus, calling him “good” in the moral sense is nonsensical. There is no morally good atheist, because there really is no objective morality. At best, morality is the mass delusion shared by humanity, protecting us from the cold sting of despair.” — Pastor Rick Henderson, ‘Why There Is No Such Thing as a Good Atheist’

Our ability to think impartially is not ‘mass delusion’. Taking a moral stance means adopting a non-partisan attitude.

Sundry

Frank Turek said: “the only reason I know what was good is because there’s a standard of good outside myself, and that’s God’s nature.”

Turek continued, “As soon as we see something evil, we know it’s evil.”

The important thing to know here is that Turek does not say that he knows the difference between good and evil because of the Bible. The Bible is not a manual on morality. The Bible mentions behavior, which is good and bad.

Take for example marriage. Most Christians will insist that a proper moral marriage is one man and one woman. But King David is a very important person in the Old Testament, and he had 13 wives. Ask the Christian if King David was a moral person, or if his Marriages were moral. An honest Christian will say no. One must then wonder why the Bible spends so much time telling a story about such an immoral person.

Turek does not fall into that trap. We need to pay special attention. The deep thinking Christians that I know don’t claim that the Bible is the source of morality, but that we know morality. In other words, they say that God created it and wrote it on our hearts. That will also admit that Christians and atheist alike have the same morals written on your hearts. That’s what gives them the arrogance to claim that atheist are ignoring the morals of God, which they know through this mechanism.

Also, it’s odd that Turek credits the nature of God with the source of these moral guidelines. He’s not saying that God decided that ex is moral and why is immoral, but rather God had no choice in this. It comes from God’s nature means that The way God is reflects the morality of the universe.

An atheist doesn’t see it much different than this. The nature of God is the nature of the universe. There can be no difference. Even for a Christian, they understand that if God has a nature, then clearly the universe he creates will have that nature as well, or else will be created according to that nature.

Atheist recognize that the universe has a nature. There is a cer-

tain way that the universe is. We talk about physical laws, and we understand that there are facts about the universe which reflect the nature of the universe. There's no functional difference between the nature of the universe and the nature of God, other than the Christian believes that there's some sort of intelligence there while the atheist believes that that nature exists without anything like a human intelligence.

So if we believe that morals are in fact from the nature of the universe, then there's not that much difference between the atheist and Frank Turek.

We might also have a discussion of what it means to be intelligent. If intelligence is the ability to make the decisions, then can't we say that evolution itself is intelligent. I'm not saying that there is an intelligence behind evolution that steps in and makes decisions, but rather the process of evolution itself Forms a decision making mechanism. That is evolution, decides on the better animal by simply creating all possible animals and killing the ones that aren't the best. That may not strike you immediately yes being in intelligence, but the more we learn about human intelligence the more we find that that's pretty much what humans do. We imagine a set of possible future scenarios, and then we eliminate those scenarios which appeared to have a bad outcome. Ultimately, we pick the scenario that we think is going to be best. It's a kind of an evolution of ideas.

The same question might be asked about the trait of creativity. A creative person will start with some sort of brainstorming about what is possible and then eliminate those things that either can't be done or don't work out. Creative person has no control over the ideas that occur to them initially. There's a lot of exercises one can do to try to increase the number of possible opportunities that you think of, but at the end of the day, an idea either comes to you or it doesn't. From that point on it's a matter of selecting the best, putting these ideas to some sort of competition, and then choosing. Can't one say that evolution is creative in the same way? Again, I'm not suggesting that evolution has thought processes and has some sort of a mental place where these ideas are sort out. Clearly, I'm talking about simply

creating all of the forms that can be created, and then ultimately selecting the best ones.

CHAPTER 8

OBJECTIVE MORALITY

Objective morality (also known as Moral Objectivism or Moral Realism) is *the philosophical belief that moral principles and values are universally true and exist independently of human opinion, cultural norms, or personal feelings.*

Tip

Bob feeds the orphans. This is a good act because humans only survive when the tribe survives. Those children may be in need of help today, but in the future they may be in a position to help Bob in return. Sam does not feed the orphans. This is bad because when the children starve, the tribe would be smaller, and there might be a time that Sam could use help but it is not there.

In this view, moral truths are like facts about the physical world. Just as the statement “The Earth orbits the Sun” is objectively true regardless of who believes it, proponents of objective morality argue that statements like “Causing gratuitous suffering to an innocent person is wrong” are also objectively true.

At this point we have established some things:

- Morality is defined as the way to live a good life.

- Humans depend on each other to survive, so the good life is a good life in the community, and must be good for the community as well.
- Morality is then the best way to live and work together.
- Morality is not simplistic rules, but take into account and may apply differently to different contexts.
- Actions we take have objective consequences that affect others.

Therefore there will be actions that are objectively better for the community than other actions. There will be a best action to take in any given circumstance.

The Easy Cases

Morality is not arbitrary, but there are in fact real reasons that some actions are better than others.

Is the arbitrary killing of fellow tribe members (a.k.a. murder) good (or bad) for the world in general?

Consider two tribes: one says that murder is “bad” (immoral) and the other says that murder is “good” (moral). Which tribe will live longer and live better? I think that the one that believes arbitrary killing of a fellow tribe members would die out fairly quickly. People would waste tremendous effort to remain safe, and that would detract from activities that aid survival. The one that insists murder is “bad” would survive much more easily, and the tribe members would survive in the tribe as well.

Consider again two tribes: one says that stealing property from others is “bad” and the other says that stealing is “good”. Which tribe will live longer and live better? Without the assurance that you will be able to keep anything you make, you are not going to invest a lot of time into making things, such as spears or arrows to help with hunting. If stealing is good, it would be smarter to just wait for someone else to make it, and then steal it. Of course, nobody is going to actually make those things in that tribe. It should be obvious that a lack of property rights would ultimately bring about the demise of that tribe, fairly quickly.

Morals are in fact the rules for living and getting along with others. Rules that promote the well being of the entire tribe are objectively good. Those that decrease survivability are objectively bad.

Existing Is Not Knowing

There is fundamentally an objective aspect to what is and is not moral, and that is determined ultimately by survivability. That is, there exists a single best action. However there is no guarantee that I or that anyone knows what the best action is.

This is profoundly disappointing. How can it be that you have a moral system and you don't know what it is? The answer is that the best action for a situation, the best way of behaving, has to be discovered. It turns out that discovering objective morality is like discovering physical laws about the universe. The only real way to know what the action is to try a number of them and see which one works out better.

But it may take thousands of generations to actually determine whether a particular action is good or bad. We can not isolate one moral rule from the others so it might be impossible to tell which rule caused a particular tribe to fail. So we have to treat the morals all together. A tribe holds a set of morals to be true, and then that tribe either survives or it doesn't. Other tribe how different combinations, and again it is survival that says whether they are right.

The fact that I cannot tell you whether capital punishment is moral or not does not say that it is morally ambivalent. None of us are omniscient.

Good Morals Survive With The Tribe That Exhibits Them

So we have to treat the morals all together. A tribe holds a set of morals to be true, and then that tribe either survives or it doesn't.

Other tribe how different combinations, and again it is survival that says whether they are right. Occasionally societies appear with bad morals, like the Nazis, but they died out because their morals were bad. So did the communists. The fact that they died out is evidence (maybe proof) that their morals were wrong.

So it is hard to determine what is and is not objectively moral, but that does not mean that objective morality does not exist. Cultures are selected to survive based on whether their morals are “true”.

A simple moral rule can be wrong. With subjective morality, no moral rule can ever be wrong: what you think is right is right. But morality is objective because tribes and cultures survive or die based on their moral rules.

Goodness Is Equated With Existence

Sure, a particular action may be optimized to bring the best consequence to the most people, but does that make it morally good?

Morality is meaningful only as it relates to the survivability of the tribe or culture holding those morals. Morality is how we get along together. Don't murder. Don't steal. Don't sleep with a family member. Don't lie. Don't cheat on your spouse. Don't harm others unnecessarily. Don't be lazy. These are all rules that enhance the tribal fitness.

If you look at the traditional use of the term “moral” and the phrase “good life” you see that living together well means survival and flourishing.

It is true that some religions promote superstitions as moral behaviors. Cross yourself is a moral action. Saying “Amen” is a moral action. Slaughtering a lamb (or even human sacrifice) to appease an angry God would be considered a moral action. The difficulty in saying whether these are moral or not is that most superstitions have no material effect on the world. You can do them or not, and it has little effect on the flourishing of the people. In some cases the actions, like rituals, actually bring about good side effects that are not obvious. A funeral or a memorial

can help individuals and the community carry on after the loss of a loved one.

Having considered this issue from many sides I just can't find any justification for thinking that an actions can be good just because God declared it so. Every traditional moral rule has a founding in the success of the tribe. Those who break moral rules are outcast, and left to fend for themselves, thereby protecting the tribe from the person who is not working the betterment of the tribe. I don't know of any examples of moral rules that are detrimental to the success of the tribe.

Conclusion

As actions can have a material impact on the success of the tribe, so too the moral guidelines about what actions to take have a material impact on survivability. An action has a single objective consequent. There exists better and worse actions, and so there is an objective basis for morality. You can not simply say that an action is subjectively good, when the consequence of that action makes the tribe objectively worse. It is hard to know exactly what actions are moral in what situations, but we can discover these through the same kinds of experimentation that scientific investigations take.

CHAPTER 9

LOVE

What does love have to do with morality?

Love is the human superpower that makes morality work. Love is that propensity for humans to do more for someone than they expect to receive in return. Living a moral life means some sacrifice by avoiding some actions for the advantage of the community.

Gee, I would like to have that big screen TV, but I am not going to steal it. I will have to wait until I have earned enough to afford it.

Living a moral lifestyle is not altruistic. In the fullness of your life, staying on the moral track will benefit you as much as anyone else.

On a simple level, your relationships with everyone you know will be better. They don't need to fear you will steal from them, and they will trust you with things they might otherwise be guarded about.

It also extends to larger scale. My commitment to not steal, and my neighbors corresponding actions, mean that my neighborhood can exist without steel bars over the windows. Everyone sees the benefit, and so we all benefit.

Love is when you truly wish the best for others, and morality is the definition of living life the best. When you do something, you will try to do what is "good" for them, and morality defines what is good for them. You know that stealing is bad, so you

don't steal.

Love extends to strangers in your community. If you saw a person dying in a ditch on the side of the road, you would help them. It might be inconvenient to do so, but we all are willing to do so, because such actions benefit everyone. Of course someday it might be me down in that ditch, but it is really not self interest in that directly way that drives the behavior. Instead, it is simply the knowledge that some actions are good, so we do them, and some actions are bad, and so we don't.

We want to live the best life possible, and as a consequence the entire community benefits along with us. That is the meaning of morality, and that is the consequence of love.

CHAPTER 10

A MODEST REQUEST

This book says impossible to know what is and is not the right thing to do. How can I then suggest things that you should are should not do? How could I know that? The miracle of the human conditions: we can talk about what is and is not good, without being 100% certain that we are right or wrong.

I hope that my non-believing friends will see that subjective morality is referring to a superficial aspect of morality. This is about the claims that people make about their beliefs, and about their intentions. Such as “I believe capital punishment is immoral.” We simply can’t know whether this is true or not. Maybe someday we will know, but for now it is a guess, it is an estimate.

Such a statement does reveal that the speak intends to act in concordance with that. They will vote against capital punishment, and might even object on moral grounds to refuse to participate in such an action. These claims are evidence of a subjective opinion: I find capital punishment distasteful.

But I still might be wrong. It could be that everyone is better off, and that all of society lives better, if we execute our worst offenders. I can’t say for sure, but I have confidence that in the fullness of time the morality of capital punishment will be discovered if we continually strive to find those facts.

People have subjective opinions about morality, but that is not

the same thing as saying that morals are subjective themselves. Your favorite flavor of ice cream is a subjective opinion, and if you like Cherry Garcia best, nobody — absolutely nobody — can say you are wrong. Morality is about living your life properly, and it is ultimately about how we get along together. This is not the flavor of the month: how you live your life has objective consequences, and therefore there is an objective reality in what is good and bad when it comes to survival of everyone.

On the other side are my believing friends who clearly recognize that morality can not be arbitrary. They rightly say that we can not just decide that an action is good or bad. We agree that morals are objective.

My religious friends make the hasty assumption that moral rules are dictated by a God. That is a possibility, yet they should recognize that there are entirely natural sources for moral behavior. Stealing a neighbor's property is not wrong because God says so, but because a culture that considered it good to steal would never survive. Morality is not the arbitrary whims of an intelligence in the sky, it is in fact the rules to live by so that we all live the best possible. While it is possible that moral laws were laid down by lawgiver, it is not necessary for that to be the case. There are other perfectly good explanations for moral intuition and moral instincts. We must remain open minded to discover the true secrets of the universe.

My request is for all my friends to see that morality is a property of the universe that is related directly to our physical form. Morality is that behavior that allows us to live best together depending on our physical form. That follows directly from survivability.

We live the best life when we make the world better for each other. It will be hard work to discover the right way for people to live together on this small planet spinning through space. It will take untold generations of work along with many missteps along the way. We can do it.

The discovery of the most successful way to live together is in fact the most important goal of human existence.

APPENDIX A

REFERENCES AND RESOURCES

Web Sites

- Humanism: Morality without God
- Allan, Leslie 2016a. Is Morality Subjective?, Rational-Realm.com, <https://www.RationalRealm.com/philosophy/ethics/is-morality-subjective.html>
- Shook, John 2015. Humanism, Moral Relativism, and Ethical Objectivity in The Wiley Blackwell Handbook of Humanism, 1st edn,
- John Rawls
- Massimo Pigliucci - Stoic Cosmopolitanism

YouTube Videos

- Humanism: Morality without God
- Evolutionary morality Mike Isreatel — Long discussion on how morals have evolved.
- Can evolution explain morality? Steven Pinker says explaining altruism by evolution is not all, but also logic is involved.

- How I changed my mind about objective morality - Peter Singer believes objective moral truth can exist. Based on reason. Non natural realist. Most people should agree that agony is objectively bad. Intuitions are mostly right, but logic should rule over it. Unusual situations, like ticking bomb scenario.
- Objective Morality — Matt Dillahunty says objective morals come from understanding the consequences of action. No absolute right and wrong. We care about well being, but very situational. Foundations of morals are subjective. Christians say that moral intuitions come from good, but intuition can be wrong, and how can god be wrong?
- Does Objective Morality Exist? - A philosophical presentation and discussion - Jeffrey Kaplan makes an interesting argument.
- How Did Human Morality Evolve? - Victor Kumar — gene / culture coevolution (alcohol flush, lactose intolerant) gives a good defense of evolutionary morality. Defines morality as “emotion” feeling that we have. Also social norms. Just more effective cooperation. Culturally transmitted. Care giving to children is moral. We are social learners. Moral emotions, sympathy, trust, respect.
- Derek Parfit — Full Address — Oct 10, 2015, Derek Parfit’s book *On What Matters* was very influential in Peter Singer’s switch to accepting objective moral truths. For those interested in understanding something of Parfit’s influential metaethics, watch from the 39 to 48 minute marks.

APPENDIX B

ORIGINS OF OBJECTIVE MORALS

In the face of religious polemics, counting ourselves as 'subjectivists' or 'relativists' puts us at a significant social and political disadvantage. — Leslie Allen, Director Humanists of Australia

Six different theories on morality that require no divinity:

- Ideal Observer (David Hume)
- Categorical Imperative (Immanuel Kant)
- Utilitarianism (Jeremy Bentham, John Stuart Mill, Peter Singer)
- Prescriptivism (Richard Hare)
- Social Contract (John Rawls)
- Stoic Cosmopolitanism (Massimo Pigliucci, John Shook)

Ideal Observer (David Hume)

What do we mean when we say something is good? The idea observer theory was proposed by David Hume, Adam Smith, and Roderick Firth. There is a hypothetical morally perfect observer. We have to imagine this observer judging the situation.

the observer would have to be omniscient, omnipercipient, impartial, dispassionate, consistent, and otherwise normal. Such person will be able to unlock the moral truths. When we say X is wrong, what we are saying is that an ideal observer would judge it as wrong. This is a kind of moral realism.

The weakness of this theory is that nobody is omniscient, and it is hard for us to even know what an omniscient person would be like. It seems like circular reasoning: if morally good is defined what an ideal observer would see, and then it is not surprising that an ideal observer would find that to be moral.

Categorical Imperative (Immanuel Kant)

People have moral duties which they must follow as a duty. Kant's theory focusses on the morality of actions, which is different than the morality of consequences. "Act only according to that maxim whereby you can at the same time will that it should become a universal law." The problem is that conditionality can not be attached to the imperatives. Each act has to be defined as an independent act. For example lying: Kant has nothing to say about the Nazis that come to the Anne Frank door: lying is simply lying and it is better that people die than that you say a falsehood. We know that context matters, and that an act can not be defined in such a way that it is independent of context.

Utilitarianism (Jeremy Bentham, John Stuart Mill, Peter Singer)

Utility is that aspect of an action that corresponds to whether the action augments or diminished the happiness of the party in question. Bentham ties the moral value of an action to the amount of happiness that it produces, and/or the amount of pain it reduces. Everything is a means to something else, until you get to pleasure. Pleasure is an end in itself. Pain is an end in itself as well. Aggregate across all people to find out the total good.

Utilitarianism is a kind of individualistic version of consequentialism. the only thing that matters is the result of your actions. If you do something that nobody even notices, then there is no consequence of the action, and the action is neither good nor bad.

This is an interesting theory because: it provides an independent test for moral teaching. It gives us a straightforward test to apply to moral claims. It renders a verdict on any possible action. The three subtheses it rests on are all plausible.

Prescriptivism (Richard Hare)

Moral words are prescriptive. Moral judgements are actually orders to do or not do something.

Social Contract (John Rawls)

Stoic Cosmopolitanism (Massimo Pigliucci, John Shook)

APPENDIX C

PARABLE OF THE HAND CHOPPERS

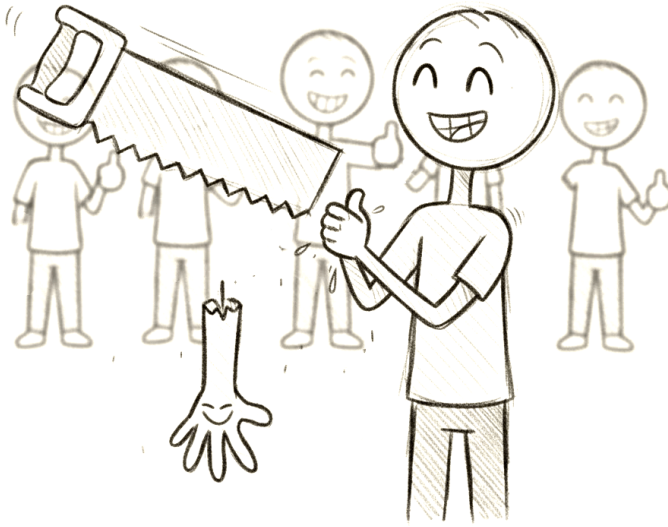
Key Takeaway

A law passed to remove everyone's right hand would be an immoral law, even if everyone agreed to it and believed it to be moral.

Situation

Imagine a tribe or a culture which for some unusual reason decided that it would be a good thing for everybody to chop off their right hands. Of course this tribe is insane because we all intuitively know that this is a very bad idea. But let's set that aside for a moment.

The tribe gets together and comes to a unanimous agreement that all right hands should be removed. They are removed surgically under anesthesia and the wound is healed without pain. There is no suffering from the hand removal process. The right hand is just cleanly removed.



Moral Assessment

Is this law good or bad?

The consequence of removing everyone's right hand would be disastrous for the tribe. There are many jobs that require two hands. It would be impossible to carry larger objects. Chopping food requires a hand to hold the food, and the other to hold the knife. The inability to get common everyday things done might escalate to the point of some people dying. Imagine an able-bodied tribe next door, would certainly out-compete in every economic activity, not to mention obviously beating them in any kind of battle.

Because this law seriously endangers the survival of the tribe, and the people within it, we can say assuredly that this law is bad. It is an objectively immoral law.

Subjective Morals Can Not Explain This

Remember that everyone in the tribe wanted this law and thought it was good. If morals were *subjective*, that would be the end of the story: the law would be good because everyone thought it was good.

We can ask the question of whether a law is moral or not because in fact morality means more than just what people believe about the situation. There is a real consequence to having that law. The law dramatically causes harm to the tribe. It is that harm that makes the law evil, and that harm is as objectively measurable as anything.

You see, it does not matter at all that everyone in the tribe thought it would be good. The law is objectively bad, and no amount of believing differently will change that. True morality can not be subjective, because our subjective opinions do not dictate the consequences of the action.

Questions

What if there was a virus that only infected the right hand, and was 100% fatal if the hand was not chopped off.

Here we see an attempt by someone to define a special case whereby the action of chopping off the hand would be good. I don't need to point out that there is no virus like that described, and it is exceedingly unlikely to ever exist with that peculiar set of symptoms. So it is a completely unrealistic hypothetical.

The point about making any scenarios is that you specify the relevant details, and whatever is omitted from the description is presumed to be "normal". Such a virus is far from normal. This question is posing an entirely different hypothetical.

It is worth pointing out that morals are situational. Lighting a fire in a fireplace is fine, lighting a fire on a crowded passenger jet while flying is not good. We can not divorce the action from the

Appendix C. Parable of the Hand Choppers

situation. One can not make a general claim about the morality of lighting fires and expect that to extend equally to all situations.

The situation in the parable is that the law was passed, and there is no such virus or anything else unusual about the situation that would make hand chopping good. Stick to the situation as it was presented.

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